

TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

being observed by the Indian command post, which radioed multiple quick response teams for reinforcements. Indian troops managed to overwhelm the Chinese within 30 minutes. Soon, both parties disengaged and commanders from both sides held a flag meeting to defuse the situation. Yangtse is one of the eight major flashpoints with China in the eastern sector of the LAC. The others are Namkha Chu, Sumdorong Chu, Asaphila, Longju, Dichu, Lamang and Fish Tail-1 & 2 in Dibang Valley.

Along with ratcheting up tension on the ground over the past fortnight, Chinese drones flew aggressive sorties repeatedly towards the Indian side. So serious was the matter that Sukhoi-30 fighter jets of the Indian Air Force had to be scrambled to tackle the threat.

In a statement in both houses of Parliament, the Union defence minister Rajnath Singh said Indian soldiers prevented the Chinese from making a landgrab and "compelled Chinese troops to return to their posts". Singh acknowledged that the scuffle led to injuries but denied any "serious casualties on our side". However, military sources have said that a few injured Indian soliders are undergoing treatment at a Guwahati hospital. In Parliament, the government was on the back foot as the Congress and other opposition parties raised questions about the clash. On December 14, they walked out of both houses demanding clarifications and the suspension of zero hour to have a discussion on the issue. Some opposition members accused the government of being in "denial mode" about the Chinese aggression.

CLEARLY, CHINA PREPARED WELL FOR THE RAID, WHICH HAD TOP-LEVEL CLEARANCE

The flag meeting between Indian and Chinese local commanders—wherein the issue was sorted out according to established mechanisms—took place on December 11. The Chinese were asked to refrain from similar actions and maintain peace. The issue has also been taken up with China through diplomatic channels. Military observers say Yangtse is a "mutually agreed" disputed area under Indian control, and PLA soldiers periodically visit the area to assert China's claim. But, after 2020, PLA activity in the area has increased, as has its troop strength. Both sides have now made massive deployments in the area.

The Chinese had made a similar attempt of intrusion in October 2021, but were similarly repulsed. It is significant that while such patrols happen in the camping season of summer, the PLA this time made a sally in winter. Observers say the Chinese army must have had to make substantial preparations to attempt such a foray in December in altitudes that can range upwards of 17,500 feet. "By doing this in winter, the PLA wanted to send out a message," says an army commander. "The possibility of tension spreading to other sectors on the eastern front cannot be ruled out."

Lt. Gen. Rakesh Sharma (retd) says that the clash at Yangtse is 'distinctive'. He says that the fact that they (the PLA) came in strength is unusual even for the Tawang sector—where differing perceptions of the border along the LAC are particularly contentious. The message of intent and belligerence is clear; it is also apparent that the raid had clearance from the highest levels in China.

Military analysts believe that for the Chinese, the Eastern Ladakh issue is now sorted to their satisfaction. "They have blocked patrolling by the Indian side (like in Depsang). Now, they are focusing on other areas and Tawang has been a standing issue with them," Lt. Gen. Sharma adds.

Some believe that the PLA's aggressive posturing on the border is always linked to India's infrastructure activities—much of it in reaction to extensive Chinese build-up and development—close to the LAC. Last month, New Delhi issued a gazette notification for constructing the 1,800 km-long Frontier Highway in Arunachal Pradesh.

The Chinese built a "Xiaokang border defence village"—they say the villages serve as buffers and prevent infiltration—across the LAC in the Yangtse area. The PLA recently upgraded a road there to improve logistics. Military observers have noted the PLA troops' possible use of the Xiaokang ('well-off') village as a base for the build-up before the intrusion at Yangtse. China has 628 such villages all along the LAC. In the light of this latest incident, they are potential staging areas for future scuffles that the PLA might orchestrate. ■